

Hip Replacement for Arthritis – UK Guide

Considering a hip replacement for arthritis? UK guide to NHS eligibility, types of hip replacement, recovery timeline, and physiotherapy after surgery.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-01-20 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Around **90,000 hip replacements** are performed annually in the UK. It is one of the most reliable operations for relieving arthritis pain, with over 90% of patients reporting excellent results lasting 15-25+ years.

When Is Hip Replacement Recommended?

- Severe hip pain affecting sleep, walking, and quality of life
 - Non-surgical treatments have been exhausted (physiotherapy, injections, weight management)
 - X-rays show significant joint damage
 - Difficulty with daily tasks like putting on shoes, climbing stairs, or getting in and out of a car
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Types of Hip Replacement



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- Total hip replacement (THR) — both ball and socket are replaced. Most common.
- Hip resurfacing — the bone is trimmed and capped rather than removed. Less common, sometimes offered to younger patients.
- Anterior approach — newer technique through the front of the hip. Potentially faster recovery but not available everywhere.

The NHS Process

- GP referral to orthopaedic surgeon
- Consultation and X-rays
- Pre-operative assessment (blood tests, general health check)
- Surgery — usually 1-2 hours under spinal anaesthetic

- Hospital stay — typically 1-3 days
 - Follow-up at 6 weeks and 1 year
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Recovery Timeline



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- Day 1 — you'll be helped to stand and take steps with a frame
- Weeks 1-6 — walking with crutches, following hip precautions
- Week 6 — most people can start driving (if automatic car)
- Weeks 6-12 — increasing activity, many return to work (desk jobs)
- 3-6 months — significant improvement, most restrictions lifted

- 12 months — full benefit usually achieved
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Hip Precautions

After surgery, you'll need to follow precautions to prevent dislocation:

- Don't cross your legs
 - Don't bend your hip past 90 degrees
 - Don't twist your leg inward
 - Use a raised toilet seat and shower seat
 - Sleep on your back or non-operated side with a pillow between your knees
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Preparing Your Home



- Remove trip hazards (loose rugs, trailing cables)
- Arrange a bed on the ground floor if possible
- Stock up on easy-to-prepare meals
- Install grab rails in the bathroom
- Arrange help for the first 2-3 weeks after surgery

Hip replacement is a life-changing operation for many people with arthritis. Discuss all your options with your surgeon and commit to physiotherapy for the best possible outcome.

Q&A

Question: When Is Hip Replacement Recommended?

Short answer: Severe hip pain affecting sleep, walking, and quality of life Non-surgical treatments have been exhausted (physiotherapy, injections, weight management) X-rays show significant joint damage Difficulty with daily tasks like putting on shoes, climbing stairs, or getting in and out of a car

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.